

Veteran Form Upload

2024-07 Research Findings

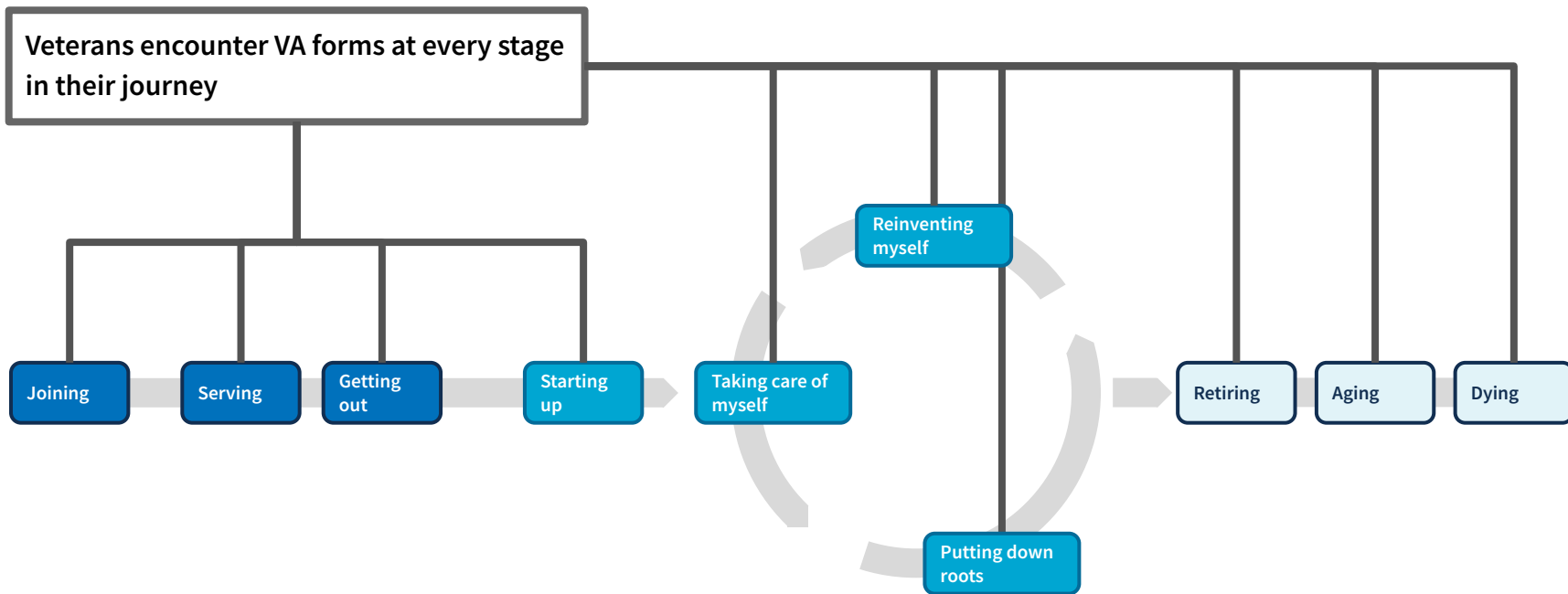
Veteran Facing Forms



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How this research maps to the Veteran journey

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For a fully detailed Veteran journey, go to

<https://github.com/departement-of-veterans-affairs/va.gov-team/blob/master/platform/design/va-product-journey-maps/Veteran%20Journey%20Map.pdf>

Serving and separation

Living civilian life

Retiring and aging

VA



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FY 24 OCTO goals supported

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Supported

Not supported

CSAT for our web products have increased by 5 points.

Number of transactions processed using our products have increased by 25%.

All new products have a faster transaction time than those they replaced.

No transactions accepted by our products have a fatal error.

Our platforms hit the “elite” level (as defined by DORA) on Deployment Frequency, Lead Time for Changes, Change Failure Rate, and Time to Restore Service.

Our platforms measure and improve the satisfaction of their internal users.

Our platforms power twice as many interactions compared to last year.

Our team health survey indicates that more than 75% feel they are having a high impact on our mission.

Our team health survey indicates that less than 25% feel high stress.

Our processes, tools and decisions are documented and easily accessible to all staff.

VA



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Participant Demographics

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Findings may not include the perspectives of the following underserved Veteran AT-user groups:

AT users of:

- Captions
- Switch Device
- Braille Reader
- Screen readers

2024-7 Form Upload Usability																						
final # of participants		10		# of AT users							3		# of no shows								5	
Category	%	Target	Study	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16			
Veterans																						
Based on current VA statistics																						
Age 55-64+	50.00%	5	1	1	1	1	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1			
Cognitive Disability	50.00%	5	3	1	0	0	0	0	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Mobile user	50.00%	5	4	1	0	0	0	0	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1			
Rural	25.00%	Null	1	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
No degree	25.00%	Null	2	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0			
Other than honorable	21.00%	Null	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Immigrant origin	17.00%	Null	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Women	10.00%	Null	5	0	0	1	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	1	1	0	0	1	1			
Expat (living abroad)	0.40%	Null	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Race																						
Based on VA's projected statistics																						
White	60.00%	Null	5	1	1	0	1	1	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Black	15.00%	Null	4	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1			
Hispanic	12.00%	Null	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0			
Biracial	3.00%	Null	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0			
Asian	3.00%	Null	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Native	0.30%	Null	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0			
LGBTQ+																						
LGBTQ+ Veterans are 5 times as likely to have PTSD																						
Gay, lesbian, or bisexual	--%	Null	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Transgender	--%	Null	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0			
Nonbinary, gender fluid, ge	--%	Null	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Assistive Tech (AT)																						
Beginner AT User	50.00%	0	3	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1			
Experienced AT User	50.00%	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Desktop Screen Reader (S	20.00%	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0			
Mobile Screen Reader (SR)	20.00%	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Magnification/Zoom	20.00%	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Speech Input Tech (Siri, Dr	20.00%	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Hearing Aids	20.00%	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Sighted Keyboard	10.00%	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Captions	--%	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Switch Device	--%	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Braille Reader	--%	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0			

[Participant Tracker on Google Sheets](#)



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Form Upload Background

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Today, Veterans and Veterans Service Organizations (VSOs) have limited online options for submitting forms to the VA.

There are numerous forms without digital alternatives, making it especially difficult, if not impossible, for AT users to submit digital copies of completed .pdf forms. We aim to support an accessible method for submitting a completed form on VA.gov.



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Accessibility concerns

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QuickSubmit is a commonly used service where authenticated users can upload a completed form, either filled out online or by hand.

Jeana Clark, an accessibility specialist embedded into the Veteran-facing Forms, audited QuickSubmit and identified launch-blocking issues per VA.gov and WCAG standards.

**jeana-adhoc**
opened this issue on Feb 13 · 2 comments

Closed

Accessibility Testing for Veteran Facing Forms - Quick Submit #76159

Product information

- ☒ Team name, product name, and feature name have been added to the title of this issue.
- ☒ Team label, product label and feature label (if applicable) have been added to this issue.

Who completed the use of color and color contrast test?

@jeana-adhoc

Main url used for testing

Use of color and color contrast checks

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Veteran File Upload | 09/16/2024

We defined the following requirements for an MVP:

- Offer an upload option for authenticated users who access VA Form detail pages for select forms.
- Include the newest iteration of the file input component from USWDS, v3
- Perform some file validation to reduce errors or delays downstream
- Surface profile data that will be submitted along with their file as metadata
- Submit file through Lighthouse Benefits Intake API
- Monitor submissions the same way we currently monitor digitally completed and submitted forms
- Display a Confirmation page after they upload which is part of a separate epic - see above

VA

User

Menu

Here's how you know

VA

User

Menu

Here's how you know

VA

User

Menu

Here's how you know

VA Form 21-0779

Request for Nursing Home Information in Connection with Claim for Aid and Attendance

Related to: Disability

Form last updated: October 2023

When to use this form

Use VA Form 21-0779 if you're a resident of a nursing home and you're providing supporting information for your claim application for VA Aid and Attendance benefits.

Download form

Download this PDF form and fill it out. Then submit your completed form on page. Or you can print the form and mail it to the address listed on the form.

Download VA Form 21-0779

Submit completed form

After you complete the form, you can upload and submit it here.

Start uploading your form

Related forms and instructions

VA Form 21-2680

VA Form 21-0779

Request for Nursing Home Information in Connection with Claim for Aid and Attendance

1 of 3 Upload file

Upload your file

You'll need to scan your document or use the device you're using to submit this application, such as your computer, tablet, or mobile phone. You can upload your document from there.

Guidelines for uploading a file:

- You can upload a .pdf, .jpeg, or .png file
- Your file should be no larger than 25MB

Upload VA Form 21-0779 (*Required)

Drag file here or choose from folder

Continue

Back

VA Form 21-0779

Request for Nursing Home Information in Connection with Claim for Aid and Attendance

2 of 3 Review information

Review your information

When you submit your form, we'll include the following personal information so you can track your submission's status:

Ziggy Ignotts

Social Security number: ***-**-2139

Zip code: 12590

Note:

If you need to update your personal information, please call us at 800-827-1000 (TTY:711). We're here Monday through Friday, 8:00am to 9:00pm ET.

Continue

Back

VA Form 21-0779

Request for Nursing Home Information in Connection with Claim for Aid and Attendance

3 of 3 Submit

Personal information

Name

Ziggy Ignotts

Zip code

12590

Social Security number

***-**-2139

Note:

If you need to update your personal information, please call us at 800-827-1000 (TTY:711). We're here Monday through Friday, 8:00am to 9:00pm ET.

Continue

Back

Files you uploaded

file.ext

5 KB

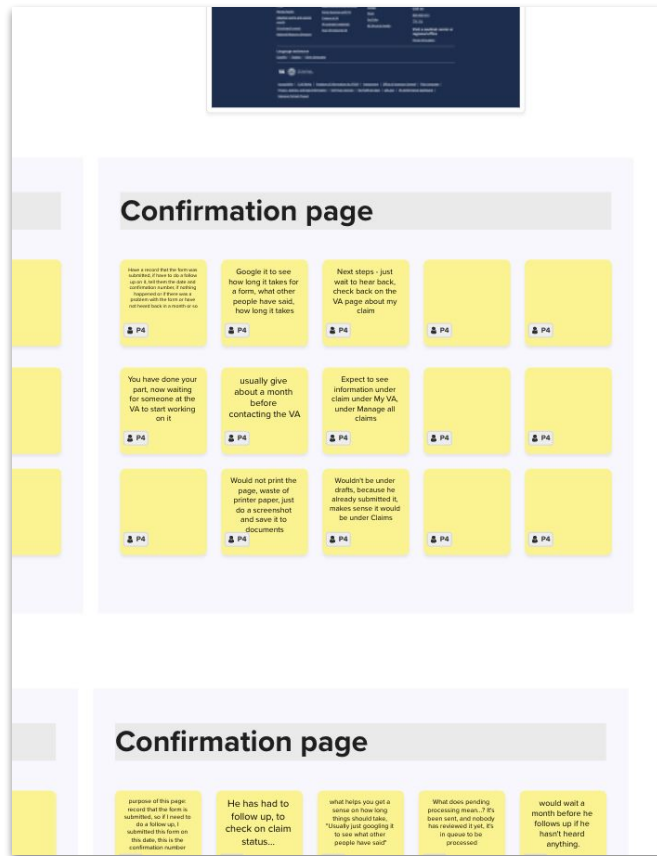
Research methodology

Veteran File Upload | 09/16/2024

Engineers built a coded prototype in staging, and we conducted 10 remote moderated sessions with Veterans, including 3 AT users and 3 users with self-reported cognitive challenges.

We provided test credentials for the purposes of exploring the authenticated experience only.

After a warm-up discussion, we directed participants to find a method of uploading VA Form 21-0779 to satisfy a request from VA regarding an open Aid and Attendance claim.



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Findings

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1. Veterans did not follow a consistent path to form upload, and many struggled to find the form detail page, the only place the link existed.
2. Although expectations varied, task-completion rates for submitting the form were high, and participants appreciated the 3-step simplicity of uploading, reviewing, and submitting their form.
3. The new primary action link worked as expected. We've documented one small issue related to magnification | [#1554](#)
4. The v3 File Input component works as expected for sighted users on mobile and desktop. We recommend further testing with AT-users.
5. Ease-of-use is not the only factor Veterans consider when deciding how to submit documents to VA.
6. The design did not include enough detail or instruction.



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Finding 1: Details

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Veterans didn't follow a consistent path to form upload, and many struggled to find the form detail page, the only place the link existed.

Several participants immediately chose to sign in with test credentials after arriving at staging.va.gov. Of the participants who signed in, many of them expected to find access to an upload option somewhere in their MyVA page. Participants looked all over VA, with little consistency.

"Personally, I would just go to Google, before I even log in." - P7

Some users felt that the process might be easier for others who are more technically savvy, or who don't rely on assistive technology.

"My son can go faster because he can see what he's doing." P16, AT-user



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Finding 2: Details

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Although expectations varied, task completion rates for submitting the form were high, and participants appreciated the 3-step simplicity of uploading, reviewing, and submitting their form.

Participants described expectations similar to the design, and Veterans considered the flow to be a familiar pattern. Some Veterans we spoke with are accustomed to physically driving to VA facilities to hand in their paper forms, which adds an enormous burden to the task of submitting a single document.

Participant number Six shared how a medical condition exacerbates the challenge of driving to a VA facility to physically hand off a paper form to a VA employee.

“I can't get out very much, because I pass out a lot. When I go to the VA it's hard for me to get around. And they won't give me a wheelchair, but because I pass out they escort me around. I have to go from one end of the building to the other side of the building to turn it in...



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Finding 2: Details

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Although expectations varied, task completion rates for submitting the form were high, and participants appreciated the 3-step simplicity of uploading, reviewing, and submitting their form.

Several participants were pleased with the experience and wanted to know when it would be available:

"So far you're going in the right direction. That ship and send thing was great. It's still easier than printing it out, filling it out, and figuring out which department to send it to. It's a ton of phone calls to figure that out." P6

"[I] would not change anything, it is fantastic, it is a start, technology making life easier." P3, AT-user

"It took less than 5 minutes, good job" P12

"I'm excited about this option!" P7



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Key finding 3: Details

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The new primary action link worked as expected for sighted users

Once participants arrived on the Form Upload page, we asked them what they considered the purpose of the page to be. We intentionally did not draw attention to the new action link treatment in order to gauge how noticeable it was.

While some participants seemed unphased by the additional component, other sighted participants remarked on the new link without prompting (P1, P2, P4, P7, and P12).

We didn't observe enough screen reader users interacting with the new treatment to be able to truly evaluate the button vs. link debate. Due to issues with assistive technology, not every participant we spoke with interacted with the Form Upload detail page, where we placed the new primary action link.



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Key finding 4: Details

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The v3 File Input component works as expected for sighted users

Before participants loaded Step 1, we asked them to describe what they expected the next page to include. Afterward, we asked them to reflect on the experience. Most participants accurately described a short process that involved accessing a file on their device and interacting with some personal data, whether reviewing data or providing it.

"Going through the process was pretty standard for most websites for uploading a form or file" P4

"[Form Upload] makes logically complete sense and an improvement over the way it was when I last tried it." P2

Some users pointed out that the copy in the component does not translate to mobile devices:

"You can't really drag files on your phone" P7



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Key finding 5: Details

Veteran File Upload | 09/16/2024

Ease-of-use is not the only factor Veterans consider when deciding how to submit documents to VA.

Participants described their experience with forms across VA business lines. From managing travel pay to filing for increases, we heard multiple examples of how past experiences influence Veterans' trust in VA, and themselves.

Veterans who have had bad experiences with digital uploads may continue to hand-deliver them if they run into obstacles:

"I've done this before where I can upload a form. But sometimes they don't get it! So then I have to take it in." P6



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Key finding 5: Details cont'd

Veteran File Upload | 09/16/2024

Ease-of-use is not the only factor Veterans consider when deciding how to submit documents to VA.

The level of perceived complexity and relative consequences of mistakes heavily influence how Veterans choose to navigate VA. One participant attributed submission problems to VA's complicated organizational structure.

Based on personal experience, many Veterans have a negative perception of what happens after submitting a document, form, application, etc. to VA. Their reliance on VSOs, who file documents with VA en masse, is closely tied to their anxiety around making mistakes during the claim life-cycle.

Each VA is a standalone unit and they're not connected. I go to 3 VAs in Michigan. And the computers don't talk to each other, they aren't connected.

- P6

"It's like trying to pull your own teeth rather than going to the dentist."

- P14, describing what it's like to manage your own claim

"If I filled it out wrong, I could be homeless or dead"

- P11

VA



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Key finding 6: Details

Veteran File Upload | 09/16/2024

The current design does not include enough detail or instruction.

Given the potential impact of simple mistakes, users must understand the services' features and limitations. Participants technical know-how varied greatly, and additional detailed instructions would benefit all users, especially those with cognitive difficulties.

2 potentially harmful misconceptions rose to the surface:

1. Some participants believed the personal data they saw was extracted from the uploaded document when it was pulled from their profile. If users fail to reconcile the data, form processors will have to contact the Veteran and instruct them to fill out and submit a replacement form.
2. Some participants assumed VA.gov would run validation on the uploaded file. In reality, mistakes on the paper form would go unnoticed until a VA employee processes it. At that point, they would have to contact the Veteran and request a new form.



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Design changes

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1. Insert an introduction page between the form-detail search result page and step one of the form upload
2. Re-order the steps in the flow so personal information is collected first, and the form upload comes second.
3. Include contextual, dismissible instructions throughout the flow



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Next steps

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- ✓ Incorporate feedback and recommendations into design
- ☐ Coordinate with CAIA
- ☐ Implement changes in staging
- ☐ Complete staging review
- ☐ Select MVP forms for Form Upload feature roll-out